The latter half of this period covers the appearance of various janapadas, or principalities, in the Indo-Gangetic plain. These then merged to form the mahajanapadas, or kingdoms, the most prominent of them being the Magadhan empire, which lasted from 680 BCE to 345 BCE , but under different dynasties. This was the period when Buddhism and Jainism emerged as new religious and philosophical streams. Sanskrit and Prakrit were written in the Brahmi script, and later in the Kharosthi script.

The Warring States period (475–221 BCE): The Zhou kingdom broke up into several fiefdoms, and there was a lot of internecine warfare. Seven major states emerged – those of the Qin, Chu, Zhao, Wei, Han, Yan and Qi. They were finally conquered by the Qin, and a unified and relatively centralized empire was established for the first time in Chinese history.

The first unified empire covering most of the Indian subcontinent was established by Chandragupta Maurya in 322 BCE . The Mauryan empire lasted till 185 BCE . King Ashoka of the Mauryan empire reigned from 268 BCE to 232 BCE . The emergence of ancient Tamil Sangam literature was around 300 BCE .

The Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE): This was the first Chinese imperial dynasty having unified the central Chinese plains under its rule. The Mauryas still ruled in India.

The Han dynasty (206 BCE –220 CE): This was the second imperial dynasty of China; it has also given its name to its largest ethnic group, the Han. The Han built large sections of the Great Wall of China to keep out invasions by the steppe tribes to the north and east of the kingdom. It established a political and social order based on Confucian principles. Buddhism came to China from the Central Asian caravan route with the first Buddhist temple, Bai Masi (White Horse temple), being established in Luoyang in 68 CE under the patronage of Emperor Ming of Han. The Han empire covered most of what is now eastern China and parts of southern China.

During this period, India was ruled by the later Mauryas and the Kushan empire (30–375 CE), which covered northern India up to the Vindhyas in the south and included the Indo-Bactrian region on the western flank of